

MAKERERE UNIVERSITY



**COLLEGE OF COMPUTING AND INFORMATION SCIENCES
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Question 1(a)

Cultural differences fundamentally shaped the communication dynamics of the bootcamp producing misinterpretations that were rooted in contrasting cultural frameworks rather than individual shortcomings.

Uganda and Japan are characterised as collectivist, high-context cultures, where group harmony is prioritised over individual expression and meaning is conveyed implicitly through context, tone, and relationship (Hall, 1976; Hofstede). The Ugandan and Japanese participants' pausing, indirect phrasing and avoidance of direct rejection were therefore culturally coherent behaviours, expressions of respect and relational sensitivity but not indecisiveness. Hofstede (2001) identifies collectivist cultures as those where individuals suppress personal views to preserve group cohesion, which explains why the individuals showed restrained participation.

American and German participants are characterised as individualistic and low-context cultures. They interpret meaning through explicit verbal content and associate directness with professionalism and competence (Kittler et al., 2011). Encountering indirect responses, they evaluated these through their own cultural lens thus misreading silence and hedged language as unpreparedness. Conversely, Ugandan students experienced this directness as dismissiveness, since, in high-context cultures, bluntness without relational groundings is perceived as disrespectful (Hall, 1976).

These divergences confirm Mahadevan and Steinmann's (2023) argument that culturally diverse virtual collaborations fail not from lack of skill but from the absence of shared interpretive frameworks across cultural communication systems.

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Question 1(b)

The concepts of high-context communication (HCC) and low-context communication (LCC) were introduced by anthropologist Edward T. Hall (1976) to describe the degree to which meaning in communication depends on context rather than on explicit verbal content.

In high-context communication, meaning is largely embedded in the surrounding context, the relationship between speakers, shared history, tone, silence and non-verbal cues rather than in the spoken or written words themselves (Nam, 2015). The speaker conveys intention implicitly, and it is the listener's responsibility to interpret meaning by reading between the lines. In the bootcamp scenario, the Ugandan and Japanese participants illustrated high-context communication (HCC) when they used phrases such as "that may be difficult" or "we can think about it further." These were not vague statements, they were culturally encoded refusals or reservations, communicated indirectly to preserve group harmony and avoid public confrontation (Hall, 1976). Their silence before responding similarly carried communicative weight, signalling thought deliberation rather than confusion.

In low-context communication, meaning is explicit, direct and contained within the message itself, with little reliance on contextual inference (Hall & Hall, 1990, as cited in Nam, 2015). American and German participants demonstrated low-context communication by expressing disagreement and assessment openly and immediately. From their cultural standpoint, clarity and efficiency are hallmarks of professionalism. Based on the implicit responses of their peers, they decoded these through low-context lens thus misinterpreting indirectness as indecisiveness. This conflict illustrates Hall's (1976) argument that neither style is inherently superior; misunderstandings arise when communicators assume their context-use norms are universally shared.

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Question 1(c)

Nonverbal communication encompassing gestures, silence, turn-taking cues, facial expressions and body language constitutes of a fundamental layer of meaning that frequently operates independently of spoken language. In intercultural settings, however, these elements are among the most common sources of misinterpretation, precisely because their meanings are culturally constructed rather than universal (ResearchGate, 2025).

Gestures radically different meanings across cultures. The thumbs-up on camera during the bootcamp illustrates this explicitly. While widely received as a sign of approval in American and European contexts, the same gesture can be perceived as dismissive or offensive in parts of West Africa and the Middle East (Morrison, as cited in *Reader's Digest*, 2024). Neither interpretation is incorrect, both are products of distinct cultural socialisation.

Silence is equally loaded. In high-context cultures such as Uganda and Japan, pausing before responding signals thoughtfulness and respect (Hall, 1976). In low-context cultures, silence in conversation creates discomfort and is read as uncertainty or disengagement (Maricopa Open, 2023). The complaints about participants "hiding behind silence" during the bootcamp reflect precisely this low-context misreading of a high-context communicative practice.

Turn-taking norms further compounded the tension. Low-context communicators tend to follow faster, overlapping conversational patterns, asserting their contributions promptly. High-context communicators wait for clear pauses, interpreting rapid responses as interruption and disrespect (ResearchGate, 2025). This structural mismatch allowed some participants to dominate discussions while others withdrew, not from lack of contribution but from other adherence to different conversational protocols.

Collectively, these nonverbal dynamics demonstrate that effective intercultural communication requires conscious awareness of spoken cultural codes, not merely language proficiency.

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Question 1(d)

Addressing intercultural communication breakdowns in online collaborative settings requires deliberate institutional and pedagogical intervention rather than assuming that exposure to diversity alone produces understanding.

First, universities should integrate **intercultural communication training as** a structured component of any international programme or bootcamp. Korte et al. (2023) found that students who engaged in facilitated intercultural reflection during online collaborative courses developed significantly greater cultural sensitivity than those who participated without such scaffolding. Pre-bootcamp orientation sessions that explicitly introduce participants to concepts such as high-context and low-context communication, turn-taking norms, and gestures variability would have directly mitigated the tensions observed.

Second, institutions should establish **clear communication protocols at the outset of collaborative activities** including agreed response times, turn-taking conventions, and guidelines on the use of gestures and emojis in video calls. Hackett et al. (2023) demonstrated that structured facilitation and explicit co-production norms significantly improved intercultural competence outcomes in Collaborative Online International Learning (COIL) programmes.

Third, facilitators should adopt **culturally inclusive participation formats such as** asynchronous discussion boards, written reflection prompts, and rotating discussion leadership which afford high-context communicators adequate time to contribute meaningfully without being disadvantaged by the pace of the live discussion (Frontiers in Communication, 2022). Finally, organisations should appoint intercultural mediators or cultural liaisons within diverse teams to identify and resolve misinterpretations early, preventing them from escalating into sustained conflict (Sarwari et al., 2024).

Together, these measures shift the responsibility for intercultural understanding from individual participants to institutional groups where it most appropriately belongs.

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Question 2(a)

Multicultural workplaces are sites where race, language, stereotypes and bias intersect in ways that profoundly distort the quality and fairness of communication. Far from being neutral exchanges of information, workplace interactions are shaped by historically embedded hierarchies that privilege certain voices and marginalise others.

Race operates as a lens through which communicative competence is frequently and unfairly evaluated. Research on structural racism in organisations demonstrates that workers of colour routinely experience a gap between their actual qualifications and how those qualifications are perceived, because negative racial stereotypes activate before professional credentials are properly assessed (Byrd, 2022). In the scenario, the comment “your English is surprisingly good” directed at the Asian employee is an example of this dynamic, it frames linguistic proficiency as unexpected, effectively subordinating the individual’s established competence to a racial preconception.

Language and accent further compound these inequities. Hidge et al.(2022) establish that non-native accents in professional settings attract disproportionate scrutiny, with listeners frequently conflating unfamiliar accent pattern with lower intelligence or reduced credibility. The Northern Ugandan employee being mocked for his pronunciation illustrates precisely what Diversity Trust (2023) terms *linguistic racism*: the use of language

differences as instruments of exclusion and stigmatisation rather than as neutral features of cultural identity.

Stereotypes operate by reducing complex individuals to simplified group representations. Stereotypes content theory (Cuddy et al., 2007, as cited in Hideg et al., 2022) posits that racial and ethnic minorities are frequently evaluated as less competent than majority group members regardless of actual performance. When stereotypical narratives become institutionalised as they were through the Whatsapp mockery and informal social media commentary in the scenario they not only harm individuals but also actively undermine organisational cohesion and diversity (PMC, 2022).

Implicit bias is perhaps the most insidious of these forces because it operates beneath conscious awareness. The HR policy mandating “neutral professional English” reflects an institutionalised form of accent bias presenting what is, in effect, a culturally specific communication norm as an objective professional standard. Browne Jacobson (2025) found that 89% of professionals in creative sectors reported being subconsciously judged based on their accent, confirming that accent-based evaluation is pervasive even when framed in neutral professional language.

Critically, these forces do not operate in isolation. Race, language, stereotype, and bias form an interlocking system in which each reinforces the others, producing communication environments where minority employees must continuously navigate barriers that their majority-group colleagues do not face (ScienceDirect, 2023).

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Question 2(b)

The term *microaggression* was originally coined by Chester Pierce in 1970 and later systematised by psychologist Derald Wing Sue, who defined microaggressions as "brief and commonplace daily verbal, behavioural, and environmental indignities, whether intentional or unintentional, that communicate hostile, derogatory, or negative racial, gender, sexual orientation, and religious slights and insults to the target person or group" (Sue, 2010, as cited in College of DuPage Library, 2023).

Crucially, the prefix "micro" refers to the scale of individual incidents, not their impact thus cumulative exposure produces measurable and serious harm (Hyring, 2026).

Sue (2010) identifies three forms. **Microassaults** are conscious and deliberate such as the Whatsapp mockery of colleagues' speech patterns and dress in the scenario. **Microinsults** are unintentional communications that demean identity, exemplified by the comment "your English is surprisingly good," which frames linguistic competence as unexpected for someone of Asian origin. **Microinvalidations** deny or dismiss a person's lived experience such as institutional framing that treats accent bias as a neutral professional standard rather than a form of discrimination.

The effects on workplace participation are well-documented. Fattoracci and King (2023) establish that microaggressions force minoritised employees to navigate ongoing interpersonal bias with limited autonomy over how to respond, producing psychological exhaustion, reduced engagement, and self-silencing. Current psychology research further confirms that repeated microaggressions erode trust between colleagues, fragment team cohesion, and create communication climates where minority employees disengage rather than risk further marginalisation (MIT Sloan, 2025).

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Question 2(c)

The tension between professionalism and linguistic or cultural diversity is one of the most contested sites in contemporary organisational communication. It centres on a fundamental question: whose communication norms define what counts as professional, and in whose interest are those norms enforced?

Professionalism, as a workplace concept, is widely presented as a neutral standard, yet scholars working within raciolinguistic theory argue that it is anything but neutral. Emerick (2022) demonstrates that conceptions of professional communication in institutional settings operate as implicit endorsements of what he terms "white linguistic norms," informed by a standard language ideology that systematically delegitimises the communicative practices of racialised and multilingual speakers. The HR policy in the scenario, requiring all employees to use "neutral professional English," exemplifies this dynamic precisely. The label "neutral" disguises the fact that no language variety is truly neutral; rather, certain varieties have been institutionally privileged through their association with social power (arXiv, 2024).

This creates a tangible structural inequality. Loensmann (2014) finds that corporate language policies in multilingual workplaces consistently mirror the linguistic repertoires of high-status employees, thereby positioning speakers of non-dominant varieties at a systemic disadvantage regardless of their actual competence. In the scenario, the Northern Ugandan employee and the Asian employee are not evaluated on the substance of their contributions but on how closely their speech approximates a socially constructed standard.

It is important to acknowledge, however, that organisations do face genuine communicative challenges in multilingual environments. Clarity, mutual intelligibility, and shared professional frameworks are legitimate operational needs (Fluency Corp, 2024). The tension, therefore, is not between professionalism and diversity as such, but between professionalism understood inclusively and professionalism used as a proxy for cultural

conformity. Resolving it requires policies that distinguish between communicative effectiveness, which is a legitimate professional concern, and accent or dialect preference, which is not.

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Question 2(d)

Building a genuinely inclusive communication culture requires deliberate, systemic intervention at the levels of policy, training, leadership, and accountability.

First, the company should revise its language policy to distinguish clearly between communicative effectiveness and accent conformity. Rather than mandating "neutral English," the policy should instead establish clarity, mutual comprehension, and respectful exchange as its benchmarks. Loensmann (2014) demonstrates that language policies which mirror the repertoires of high-status employees systematically exclude others, and that flexible, translingual approaches yield more equitable outcomes in multilingual workplaces.

Second, the organisation should implement structured diversity and inclusion training that specifically addresses unconscious bias, microaggressions, and accent discrimination. Kiradoo (2022) identifies such training as a critical component of any DEI strategy, noting that effective programmes must go beyond awareness to equip employees with practical skills for equitable interaction.

Third, leadership must model inclusive communication actively. Ylmaz (2024) argues that inclusive communication cultures are driven from the top, and that leaders who

demonstrate empathy, active listening, and cultural curiosity set a visible standard for others to follow.

Finally, the company should establish clear, confidential reporting mechanisms for communication-related discrimination, including the social media misconduct observed in the scenario. Without accountability structures, policies remain aspirational rather than operational (Stamps, 2023). Inclusive communication culture is not simply a matter of language choice; it is a matter of institutional will.

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Question 3(a)

Code-switching is a sociolinguistic phenomenon in which a speaker alternates between two or more languages, dialects, or registers within a single conversation or communicative event. Grosjean (1982, as cited in Zhong & Fan, 2023) defines it as the linguistic behaviour wherein bilinguals or multilinguals switch between languages within the same discourse. Yim and Clement (2021) further clarify that code-switching operates both intentionally and unconsciously as a social and communicative tool to signal identity, group membership, and relational proximity.

The student in the scenario demonstrates this concept with particular clarity. Speaking Luganda at home, English in academic settings, Sheng with peers, and formal English during internship interviews represents not inconsistency but a sophisticated

communicative competence. Each language or register is selected in response to contextual demands, relational dynamics, and social expectations.

Scholars identify two primary functional categories. Blom and Gumperz (1972) distinguish between **situational code-switching**, where a change in setting or interlocutor triggers the switch, such as the student shifting from casual Sheng to formal English upon entering an interview, and **metaphorical code-switching**, where the social context rather than the physical setting drives the alternation, such as mixing languages on WhatsApp to signal intimacy or shared identity with a specific audience (Wikipedia, 2025).

Code-switching occurs for several reasons. These include filling lexical gaps in one language, signalling group solidarity, managing power dynamics, expressing cultural identity, and adapting to audience expectations (Poplack, 2001, as cited in ResearchGate, 2019). PMC (2022) further identifies stereotype threat as a driver, noting that racialised speakers often switch to dominant codes in professional contexts as a self-protective response to perceived linguistic scrutiny.

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Question 3(b)

Code-switching behaviour is shaped by an interlocking set of social, cultural, and professional forces, each of which is clearly illustrated in the student's communicative life.

Socially, code-switching is driven by the need to signal group membership, build rapport, and manage relational distance. Brdarević-Čeljo et al. (2021, as cited in ResearchGate, 2021) note that speakers draw on their multilingual repertoire to express solidarity and signal in-group identity, which explains why the student uses Sheng and urban slang with peers codes that index shared youth culture and social proximity while switching away from these registers when interacting with authority figures or employers.

Culturally, the student navigates multiple identity systems simultaneously. Speaking Luganda at home is not merely a linguistic habit but an act of cultural belonging and intergenerational continuity. Forum for Linguistic Studies (2025) establishes that code-switching is intricately connected to cultural representation and identity construction, particularly in multilingual societies where individuals occupy plural cultural spaces. The student's TikTok and WhatsApp communication further reflects this, with language mixing serving to express digital cultural identity to specific audiences.

Professionally, the dominant factor is the power differential inherent in institutional settings. Canadian Journal of Educational and Social Studies (2025) finds that contextual norms and formality exert the strongest influence on code-switching decisions, exceeding even personal identity preferences. The student's shift to formal English during internship interviews demonstrates what PMC (2022) describes as self-protective code-switching: the conscious adoption of a dominant linguistic code in response to perceived professional expectations and the implicit threat of negative evaluation if those expectations are not met.

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Code-switching carries significant communicative and social benefits, particularly in multilingual societies and increasingly connected digital spaces.

In multicultural environments, code-switching serves as a bridge between different linguistic communities, enabling speakers to maintain mutual comprehension whilst simultaneously affirming cultural identity and group solidarity. Research by Nduka and Osagie (2022, as cited in IPRJB, 2023) found that students in Nigerian universities who switched between English and indigenous languages during collaborative activities demonstrated enhanced comprehension and more inclusive participation. This directly mirrors the student's use of Luganda at home and Sheng with peers, both of which strengthen social bonds and maintain intergenerational and peer-group connections that a single-language approach would erode.

In digital communication environments, code-switching enables speakers to navigate between personal and collective identities fluidly. Dewi (2022, as cited in Wulandari et al., 2025) establishes that code-switching on digital platforms creates space for individuals to adapt to diverse audiences, and Cahyani et al. (2023, as cited in Wulandari et al., 2025) find that multilingual users are perceived as more dynamic and culturally open, which contributes positively to their social credibility. The student's mixing of languages on WhatsApp and TikTok reflects precisely this: each platform has its own communicative norms, and code-switching allows authentic, audience-appropriate self-presentation across all of them.

More broadly, code-switching represents a form of cognitive and communicative flexibility. Rather than being a deficiency, it is a resource that enables speakers to access the expressive strengths of multiple linguistic systems simultaneously (Forum for Linguistic Studies, 2025).

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Question 3(d)

While code-switching carries clear communicative advantages, it also carries risks that are particularly significant in academic and professional contexts.

The most immediate disadvantage is the perception of inconsistency. The supervisor's feedback to the student that they sometimes sound professional and at other times too casual illustrates how register variation, when unrecognised as deliberate audience adaptation, can be misread as a lack of stable professional identity. Plastow (2023, as cited in Dickinson et al., 2025) finds that individuals who traverse multiple communicative worlds often encounter institutional expectations that do not align with their self-presentation, creating professional friction that can disadvantage them in performance evaluations.

More critically, code-switching in professional settings carries significant psychological costs. Harvard Business Review, as cited in CNBC (2023), identifies that the sustained effort of suppressing one's natural linguistic identity depletes cognitive resources, reduces authentic self-expression, and contributes to burnout. McCluney et al. (2021, as cited in ScienceDirect, 2021) further note that code-switching to mirror dominant group norms, whilst increasing perceived professionalism in the short term, generates hostility from in-group members and erodes a sense of authentic belonging over time.

In academic settings, code-switching can also be misconstrued as evidence of limited language proficiency. Alenezi (2010, as cited in IJEEL, 2022) notes that code-switching has historically been associated with weaker language performers, a perception that, whilst contested, persists in some institutional contexts and can unfairly undermine the credibility of multilingual students.

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Question 4(a)

Gender stereotypes fundamentally distort how leadership communication is perceived, creating a persistent double standard in which identical behaviours are evaluated differently depending on the gender of the person exhibiting them.

At the centre of this dynamic is what Eagly and Karau (2002) term role congruity theory. The theory holds that bias against female leaders arises from a fundamental mismatch between two competing sets of social expectations. Women are expected to be communal in character, that is, warm, nurturing, and cooperative, whilst leaders are expected to be agentic, meaning assertive, decisive, and dominant. Because these two role expectations are in direct conflict, women in leadership positions face a double bind regardless of how they choose to communicate (Gender Studies, 2026).

The scenario illustrates this with precision. The female project manager communicates firmly, challenges weak ideas, and pursues deadlines aggressively. These are recognised markers of effective leadership. Yet she is described as "bossy," "aggressive," and "too emotional," whilst a male colleague using the same communication style is praised as "decisive" and "results-oriented." Tremmel and Wahl (2023) confirm that female leaders displaying agentic characteristics are rated as less likable and face greater prejudice than male leaders exhibiting identical behaviour, because dominance in women is perceived as abnormal relative to leadership norms coded as masculine.

This evaluative double standard has significant implications. When women moderate their assertiveness to appear more likable, they are then judged as weak and insufficiently

authoritative. When they assert themselves, they face the backlash documented by Eagly and Karau (2002) and later confirmed by Cha et al. (2023), who find that low legitimacy perceptions of women leaders undermine their performance opportunities and career trajectories even when their actual competence is equal to or exceeds that of their male counterparts.

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Question 4(b)

The concepts of *rapport talk* and *report talk* were originally theorised by the sociolinguist Deborah Tannen (1990) in *You Just Don't Understand: Women and Men in Conversation*, and later extended to professional environments in *Talking from 9 to 5* (Tannen, 1994). These frameworks illuminate how gendered socialisation shapes distinct communicative orientations that carry significant consequences within organisational settings.

Rapport talk refers to a communicative style orientated towards building and sustaining interpersonal relationships, affirming solidarity, and fostering emotional connection. According to Tannen, women tend to engage in rapport talk a communication style meant to promote social affiliation and emotional connection. In workplace contexts, this manifests in behaviours such as acknowledging colleagues' feelings before presenting solutions, using inclusive language (e.g., "perhaps we could consider..."), prefacing instructions with relational gestures, and engaging in small talk at the outset of meetings. As Tannen (1994) observes, women in positions of authority frequently employ indirect phrasing such as "What do you think about doing it this way?" not out of uncertainty, but as a relational courtesy that prioritises the listener's dignity. Such behaviour, whilst

constructive in fostering team cohesion, is often misread in hierarchical organisational cultures as a lack of decisiveness or authority.

Report talk, by contrast, is a communicative style centred on the transmission of information, demonstration of knowledge, and the assertion or negotiation of status. Men's communication is characterised by "report" talk, which is direct and assertive, whereas women's communication is characterised by "rapport" talk, which is more emotional and personal. In the workplace, report talk is evident when individuals present arguments confidently, use declarative statements to convey expertise, resist expressing uncertainty, and frame conversation as a platform for competence-signalling rather than connection-building. According to Tannen, men are more likely to engage in report talk, which is primarily characterised by a focus on content, discussing public matters and demonstrating knowledge about a subject.

Applying these concepts to the scenario, the female project manager's direct questioning, assertive follow-up on deadlines, and open challenging of ideas are consistent with report talk a style typically attributed to and valorised in male leaders. Yet, because this behaviour deviates from the rapport-oriented expectations socially assigned to women, she is perceived as "bossy" and "aggressive." Her male counterpart, demonstrating an identical style, is commended as "decisive" and "results-oriented." This asymmetry underscores what Tannen (1994) describes as the *double bind* facing women in authority: if they talk in ways expected of women, they are liked but underestimated; if they talk in ways expected of men in the same position, they are seen as too aggressive.

Critically, Tannen cautions against viewing either style as inherently superior. Weinberg et al. (2019) extend this argument, demonstrating empirically that both rapport-oriented and report-oriented communicative behaviours yield distinct career rewards, and that organisations benefit most when both styles are recognised as legitimate and effective. The challenge for modern workplaces, therefore, lies not in compelling individuals to conform to a singular communicative norm, but in cultivating structural and cultural conditions that value the full spectrum of professional communication.

References

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Question 4(c)

The mechanisms of interruption, tone, and authority are central to understanding how leadership is communicated and, crucially, how it is perceived differently across gender lines in professional environments.

Interruptions function as one of the most visible markers of conversational power. Zimmerman and West (1975) demonstrated that men interrupt women significantly more often than the reverse, reinforcing traditional hierarchies of dominance in mixed-gender interactions. Frequent interruptions by men during conversations underscore the reinforcement of traditional power hierarchies. Importantly, the same behaviour carries different social weight depending on who performs it. Both men and women exhibit higher levels of power displays, in the form of verbal interruptions, when working in male-dominated groups compared to female-dominated groups, yet women who interrupt are more likely to be perceived as aggressive or disruptive, whilst men who do the same are read as assertive and engaged.

Tone operates as another contested site of gendered perception. In workplace environments, women who use assertive language are often perceived as less likable, whereas men using the same language are viewed as competent leaders. Women are socialised to adopt softer, more hedged speech, and when they deviate from this norm by raising their voice, issuing firm directives, or adopting a direct tone, they face what Tannen (1994) describes as the double bind: being penalised for speaking in ways that are simultaneously expected of leaders and inappropriate for women. The female project manager in the scenario illustrates this precisely. Her firm tone and direct questioning are functionally identical to her male counterpart's style, yet she is labelled "too emotional" and "bossy" whilst he is regarded as "decisive."

Authority, as a perceived quality, is closely tied to these communicative cues. The same communication behaviour is often evaluated differently based on the speaker's gender. A behaviour from a male could be perceived positively whilst the same behaviour performed by a female can be viewed negatively. This reflects what scholars identify as prescriptive gender stereotyping, the expectation that leaders should be agentic and assertive, and that women should be communal and accommodating. When a woman occupies a position of

authority, these two expectations collide, producing evaluative inconsistency that undermines her perceived legitimacy regardless of her actual competence (Baxter, 2010).

Collectively, interruptions, tone, and authority reveal that leadership perception is not a neutral assessment of behaviour but a deeply gendered interpretive process that disadvantages women who adopt the very communicative norms that organisations traditionally reward.

References

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Question 4(d)

Addressing gendered communication inequities requires deliberate, multi-layered organisational strategies that go beyond surface-level policy statements. Scholars and practitioners converge on the view that lasting change demands both structural reform and cultural transformation (Ezeafulukwe et al., 2024).

The first strategy is the implementation of **unconscious bias training** that specifically targets communication evaluation. Research demonstrates that evaluators consistently rate identical communicative behaviours differently depending on the speaker's gender (Baxter, 2010). Unconscious bias training seeks to raise awareness of the mental shortcuts that lead to snap judgements, often based on race and gender, about people's talents or character, with the goal of reducing bias in attitudes and behaviours at work. However, such training must be embedded in broader cultural change efforts rather than treated as a standalone intervention, as evidence suggests that training alone, without structural reinforcement, produces limited long-term effect (Equality and Human Rights Commission, 2018).

A second strategy involves the establishment of **inclusive communication norms during formal meetings and evaluations**. Organisations should introduce structured turn-taking

protocols that ensure all voices receive equal floor time, reducing the conditions under which interruption patterns systematically disadvantage women. Workplaces looking to communicate and spread norms of inclusion should carefully craft content to directly introduce employees to the notion of inclusion and simultaneously encourage people to model inclusion at work. This includes training meeting facilitators to actively redirect dominant speakers and affirm contributions from those who are routinely talked over.

Third, organisations must adopt **gender-neutral and gender-sensitive language policies** across all official communications. This involves revising job descriptions, performance appraisal frameworks, and internal communications to eliminate gendered descriptors that encode different expectations for male and female communicators. Inclusive language in all formal and informal communications to avoid gendered assumptions, as well as diverse leadership that advocates and offers representation at all levels, are critical components of a gender-inclusive workplace.

Fourth, organisations should invest in **mentorship and sponsorship programmes** specifically designed to support women in leadership communication. Mentorship provides women with safe spaces to develop assertive communicative styles, whilst sponsorship ensures that women's contributions are advocated for by senior colleagues in high-stakes settings. Ezeafulukwe et al. (2024) highlight that such programmes, when paired with accountability frameworks, demonstrably increase women's representation in decision-making roles and reduce the communicative penalties they face.

Finally, organisations must develop **transparent and standardised performance evaluation criteria** that assess leadership effectiveness on objective outcomes rather than on stylistic alignment with masculine communicative norms. Norms can be redefined through collective acts and by challenging biased criteria, such as male assertiveness being labelled "ambition" while female assertiveness is deemed "aggression." When criteria are made explicit and consistently applied, gendered interpretation of communicative style is less able to infiltrate professional assessments.

References

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Tannen, D. (1994). *Talking from 9 to 5: Women and men in the workplace*. Avon Books.

Question 5(a)

The thesis statement, "Artificial intelligence has many advantages and disadvantages in education," contains several critical weaknesses that undermine its value as an academic argument.

The first and most fundamental weakness is its lack of arguability. A weak thesis statement is vague, identifies a topic but does not specify an argument, or is a statement of fact that does not give the reader a sense of why the argument is important. The submitted statement presents a self-evident observation that virtually no informed reader would contest, offering no intellectual position for the essay to defend or develop.

The second weakness is excessive vagueness. Phrases such as "many advantages and disadvantages" provide no analytical direction. As Indiana University's Writing Tutorial Services note, a weak thesis that references "many causes and effects" is problematic because it fails to identify which specific ones the writer intends to examine (Indiana University, 2013). Applied here, the statement gives neither the writer nor the reader a clear scope for the discussion.

The third weakness is an absence of focus. The statement does not specify which dimension of education is being examined, whether access, pedagogy, assessment, or equity, nor does it indicate the writer's evaluative stance on AI's net impact. Makerere University's academic writing guidelines stress that a strong thesis must be concise, purposeful, and precise in conveying the writer's central argument (Makerere University Directorate of Research and Graduate Training, 2011). This statement satisfies none of those criteria, leaving the essay structurally directionless before it begins.

References

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Makerere University Directorate of Research and Graduate Training. (2011). *Guidelines for the format of research proposals, research reports, theses and dissertations* (2nd ed.). Makerere University.

Vanderbilt University Writing Studio. (n.d.). *Refining thesis statements*. Vanderbilt University.

Question 5(b)

Revised thesis statement:

"Whilst artificial intelligence holds significant potential for personalising learning and widening access in higher education, its uncritical adoption risks deepening digital inequality and eroding students' critical thinking capacities, necessitating structured institutional governance frameworks to maximise its benefits."

Justification:

The revised statement addresses each weakness identified in part (a). First, it is arguable. It advances a position that acknowledges AI's benefits whilst asserting a specific risk, a claim that invites debate and requires evidential support rather than simple acceptance. A strong thesis makes a definite, arguable claim and narrows the subject to a more specific and manageable topic.

Second, it is focused. Rather than gesturing broadly at "education," the revision specifies higher education and identifies concrete dimensions: personalised learning, access, digital inequality, and critical thinking. This specificity signals to the reader precisely what the essay will examine and argue.

Third, it provides a clear evaluative stance. The statement does not merely list two sides but positions them in tension and draws a purposeful conclusion, that governance is necessary. This reflects what Vanderbilt University's Writing Studio (n.d.) describes as a thesis that allows the reader to anticipate the organisation of the argument to follow.

Finally, it aligns with Makerere University's writing guidelines, which emphasise that academic writing must be purposeful, precise, and structured around a clearly stated central argument (Makerere University Directorate of Research and Graduate Training, 2011). The revised thesis satisfies all of these requirements, providing a substantive foundation upon which a coherent essay can be built.

References

Makerere University Directorate of Research and Graduate Training. (2011). *Guidelines for the format of research proposals, research reports, theses and dissertations* (2nd ed.). Makerere University.

Vanderbilt University Writing Studio. (n.d.). *Refining thesis statements*. Vanderbilt University. Question 5(C)

An effective thesis statement is the structural foundation of any academic essay. Scholars and university writing centres consistently identify several defining characteristics that distinguish a strong thesis from a weak one.

The first characteristic is **arguability**. A thesis must advance a position that is open to reasoned contestation and requires evidential support. A good thesis is argumentative, not in a negative sense, but in that it can be supported and may have counter-arguments. A statement of obvious fact or universal agreement serves no argumentative purpose.

The second characteristic is **specificity and focus**. A strong thesis statement addresses a narrow and focused topic appropriate to the length of the paper, takes a clear position on intellectual questions, and reflects the overall structure of the paper. Vague language such as "many," "various," or "society" weakens precision and leaves the scope undefined.

The third characteristic is **conciseness**. A thesis is typically expressed in one to two sentences and states the central claim without unnecessary elaboration. Makerere University's writing guidelines similarly stress that academic writing must be concise and purposeful, with the central argument conveyed clearly from the outset (Makerere University Directorate of Research and Graduate Training, 2011).

The fourth characteristic is that it must **function as a roadmap**. A thesis statement should tell the reader what the paper is about and also help guide the writing and keep the argument focused. Each body paragraph of the essay should connect back to and develop the claim made in the thesis.

Together, these characteristics ensure that a thesis statement gives direction to both the writer and the reader throughout the essay.

References

Makerere University Directorate of Research and Graduate Training. (2011). *Guidelines for the format of research proposals, research reports, theses and dissertations* (2nd ed.). Makerere University.

University of Illinois Writers Workshop. (n.d.). *Effective thesis statements*. University of Illinois.

Vanderbilt University Writing Studio. (n.d.). *Refining thesis statements*. Vanderbilt University.

Question 5(d)

A strong thesis statement functions as the organising spine of an academic essay, determining what goes in, what stays out, and how ideas progress. The thesis works as a road map, showing readers the main points that will be used to support the writer's ideas, whilst body paragraphs support the main ideas presented in the thesis.

Using the revised thesis from part (b) as a demonstration: "Whilst artificial intelligence holds significant potential for personalising learning and widening access in higher education, its uncritical adoption risks deepening digital inequality and eroding students' critical thinking capacities, necessitating structured institutional governance frameworks to maximise its benefits," this statement immediately generates three distinct body sections. The first would examine AI's benefits for personalisation and access, the second would analyse its risks concerning inequality and critical thinking, and the third would argue for governance frameworks. Each body paragraph focuses on one of the main points introduced in the thesis statement and provides evidence to support that point.

Coherence is maintained because every topic sentence traces back to the central claim. Without this anchor, paragraphs drift, arguments contradict, and the essay loses analytical direction (Makerere University Directorate of Research and Graduate Training, 2011). A strong thesis therefore does not merely introduce an essay; it governs it entirely.

References

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Question 6(a)

Understanding the distinction between facts, claims, and opinions is foundational to evaluating academic and public arguments. A fact is a statement that can be verified, whereas an opinion is a judgement or belief about a situation that may be based on facts but can differ among people. A claim, by contrast, occupies a distinct third category, functioning as an arguable assertion that demands evidential support and logical reasoning before it can be accepted as credible.

Within the Toulmin (1958) model of argumentation, a claim is the assertion that authors would like to prove to their audience, whilst grounds are the reasons, evidence, and facts that help support the claim. This distinction is critical when analysing the debate.

In the scenario, the statement that online education expanded during and after COVID-19 constitutes a **fact**, as it is historically verifiable and not subject to reasonable dispute. The

assertion that "digital learning is the most effective solution for reducing educational inequality" is a **claim of value and policy**, requiring evidence about outcomes and access before it can be sustained. Equally, the counter-assertion that "digital learning actually increases inequality because many learners cannot afford devices or internet access" is a **claim of fact**, grounded in observable conditions but still requiring empirical substantiation. Neither panellist's position qualifies as pure opinion, since both advance reasoning beyond personal preference, yet neither reaches the status of fact without supporting data (Toulmin, 1958).

References

Toulmin, S. (1958). *The uses of argument*. Cambridge University Press.

Ohio State University Press. (n.d.). *Choosing and using sources: Fact or opinion*. Ohio State University.

Question 6(b)

Evidence is the mechanism through which an argument transitions from personal assertion to verifiable scholarly discourse. Without it, even a logically coherent claim remains unsubstantiated and vulnerable to dismissal.

Evidence provides the substantiation needed to support claims and persuade an audience, demonstrating that ideas are not simply based on personal opinion or speculation but are grounded in factual information, research, or expert insights. Within the Toulmin (1958) model, evidence constitutes the grounds upon which a claim rests; a claim unsupported by grounds cannot function as a credible scholarly argument.

Applied to the debate, both panellists advance positions that require evidential reinforcement to be academically defensible. The first panellist's claim that digital learning reduces educational inequality gains credibility only when supported by empirical data, such as enrolment statistics, learning outcome studies, or UNESCO reports on distance education access in sub-Saharan Africa. The second panellist's counter-claim that digital learning deepens inequality similarly requires data on device ownership rates, internet penetration figures, and household income disparities in Uganda specifically.

Citations to the words, ideas, and arguments of scholars demonstrate that an author has conducted a thorough review of the literature and is reporting from an informed and critically engaged perspective. Evidence therefore does not merely support an argument; it

establishes the scholarly legitimacy of the writer and positions their contribution meaningfully within existing academic knowledge (Kalule, 2013).

References

Clemson University Writing Lab. (n.d.). *Incorporating evidence*. Clemson University.

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Toulmin, S. (1958). *The uses of argument*. Cambridge University Press.

Question 6(c)

Acknowledging counterarguments is not a concession of weakness; it is a hallmark of scholarly rigour. An argument that engages only with evidence supporting its own position appears selective and intellectually dishonest, diminishing its persuasive force.

Including a counterargument shows readers that the writer has carefully researched and considered both sides of the topic, demonstrating a measured, scholarly approach rather than an overly emotional or one-sided one, and helps establish the writer's credibility. This credibility, known in rhetorical terms as *ethos*, is essential in academic and public debate settings alike.

Addressing opposing views allows the writer to solidify their position by identifying and addressing potential weaknesses, and acknowledging counterarguments demonstrates intellectual honesty and fairness, helping to build trust with the audience.

Applied to the debate, the first panellist's claim that digital learning reduces inequality would be significantly strengthened by directly engaging with the opposing view, acknowledging that device and connectivity gaps exist, then providing evidence that targeted policy interventions can overcome those barriers. Similarly, the second panellist would strengthen their argument by conceding that digital learning holds genuine potential, whilst demonstrating that this potential remains unrealised without structural investment. Careful consideration of counterarguments presents the writer's awareness of opposing views, addressing the audience's expectations and reinforcing trust.

References

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Toulmin, S. (1958). *The uses of argument*. Cambridge University Press.

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Question 6(d)

The second panellist's argument, that digital learning deepens inequality because many learners cannot afford devices or internet access, is the more empirically compelling position, particularly within the Ugandan context.

The claim is not merely theoretical. A 2017–2018 survey by Research ICT Africa indicated that Uganda had one of the lowest internet penetration rates at 14 per cent, with a significant urban-rural divide, and Uganda has the highest-priced internet in East Africa, with the cost of one gigabyte standing at UGX 9,819, discouraging the adoption of online learning. Furthermore, 84 per cent of children and youth surveyed in Uganda were unable to access the internet through smartphones or tablets, rendering digital learning a structurally exclusive rather than inclusive enterprise under current conditions

These figures reveal that the first panellist's claim, whilst aspirationally valid, conflates digital learning's potential with its present reality. As the Economic Policy Research Centre (2020) concludes, learners from urban and affluent families disproportionately benefit from online education, whilst rural and low-income students are systematically excluded, meaning digital learning in its current form reproduces rather than resolves educational inequality in Uganda.

This does not dismiss digital learning's long-term promise, but any argument for its effectiveness must first honestly confront the infrastructural and socioeconomic conditions under which it operates.

References

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Question 7(a)

Academic writing is not a single act but a structured, iterative process comprising several distinct stages. The writing process is a structured approach that writers use to produce a finished piece of work, typically encompassing five key stages: planning, drafting, revising, editing, and publishing.

The first stage, **prewriting or planning**, involves selecting a topic, identifying the audience, conducting research, and organising ideas through tools such as outlines or mind maps. This stage establishes the essay's purpose and direction before any writing begins.

The second stage, **drafting**, involves translating planned ideas into connected sentences and paragraphs. The rough draft is an opportunity to get ideas down onto paper to get a first look at how ideas will work together, without concern for perfection at this point.

The third stage, **revising**, requires the writer to critically review the draft for coherence, argument strength, logical organisation, and clarity. This stage often involves substantive restructuring of content.

The fourth stage, **editing and proofreading**, focuses on correcting grammatical errors, punctuation, spelling, and formatting. Proofreading focuses on correctness, covering grammar, usage, mechanics, and punctuation, ensuring the work is polished before submission.

The fifth stage, **publishing or submission**, is the sharing of the final work with the intended audience.

Question 7(b)

Each weakness identified by the lecturer maps directly onto a neglected stage of the writing process, demonstrating that the student's overnight approach bypassed the very mechanisms through which academic quality is built.

The absence of **prewriting and planning** produced the most visible consequence: a lack of organisation. Not outlining or organising thoughts before writing leads directly to a lack of coherence and effectiveness in conveying ideas. Without an outline or research phase, the student had no structural blueprint, resulting in paragraphs that lacked logical sequencing and a thesis that failed to govern the essay's direction.

Neglecting **revision** accounted for the absence of clarity and coherence. Flower and Hayes (1981) describe the reviewing stage as involving evaluating and revising text to improve clarity, coherence, and overall quality. Without revisiting the draft, weak arguments remained undeveloped, transitions between ideas were absent, and the essay's central argument was never adequately reinforced.

Finally, skipping **editing and proofreading** directly produced the grammatical inaccuracies the lecturer noted. Procrastination and poor time management limit time available for essential steps like research, drafting, and revision, and rushed essays often lack depth, coherence, and the thoughtful analysis needed for academic success. Writing

overnight collapsed all five stages into one, ensuring that the deficiencies of each neglected stage accumulated visibly in the final submission (Kalule, 2013).

References

Flower, L., & Hayes, J. R. (1981). A cognitive process theory of writing. *College Composition and Communication*, 32(4), 365–387.

Kalule, J. (2013). *Writing right: Enhancing academic writing and research among post graduate students in public universities in Uganda*. Makerere University.

Makerere University Directorate of Research and Graduate Training. (2011). *Guidelines for the format of research proposals, research reports, theses and dissertations* (2nd ed.). Makerere University.

Question 7(c)

Understanding writing as a process rather than a one-time activity is essential because quality academic work is produced through iterative engagement, not a single sitting. The assumption that a complete, polished essay can emerge from one uninterrupted effort fundamentally misrepresents how effective writing works.

Flower and Hayes (1981) established through cognitive process theory that writing does not follow a rigid linear sequence but is instead recursive, meaning writers continuously move back and forth between planning, drafting, and revising. The recursive nature of writing emphasises that each step, from prewriting to publishing, interacts fluidly with the others, creating a dynamic and iterative process in which revision is not merely a final step but an ongoing activity that occurs at various points.

This matters because each pass through the material allows the writer to see it differently. A writer may need to return to the drafting stage to enhance an introduction with more refined language even whilst in the revising stage, demonstrating that stages overlap rather than follow neatly one after another.

In the scenario, the student treated writing as a product to be generated overnight rather than a process to be worked through deliberately. The result was an essay that reflected none of the refinement that multiple drafts produce. As Kalule (2013) observes from Makerere University research, poor academic writing among students in Ugandan universities is consistently linked to insufficient engagement with the full writing process, particularly the stages of revision and review.

References

Flower, L., & Hayes, J. R. (1981). A cognitive process theory of writing. *College Composition and Communication*, 32(4), 365–387.

Kalule, J. (2013). *Writing right: Enhancing academic writing and research among post graduate students in public universities in Uganda*. Makerere University.

Question 7(d)

Improving academic writing requires deliberate, consistent practice built around the full writing process. Several evidence-based strategies are particularly effective for university students.

The first strategy is **early planning and structured outlining**. Students should begin assignments immediately upon receipt, dedicating time to researching the topic, formulating a thesis, and constructing a detailed outline before writing a single sentence. This prevents the structural disorganisation that characterised the student's assignment in the scenario.

The second strategy is **writing multiple drafts**. Treating the first draft as exploratory rather than final removes the pressure of perfection and creates space for substantive revision. Flower and Hayes (1981) emphasise that skilled writers revisit and reshape their work recursively, a practice that fundamentally improves both argumentation and coherence.

The third strategy is **seeking peer feedback**. Peer feedback fosters a deeper understanding of academic writing criteria, promotes self-reflection, and enhances critical and analytical skills, empowering students to become more discerning producers of academic texts. Submitting a draft to a peer or writing centre before the final submission exposes blind spots that the writer cannot detect alone.

The fourth strategy is **wide and sustained reading** within the discipline. Lack of extensive reading is one of the primary reasons individuals find academic writing burdensome, as reading builds familiarity with academic register, argumentation structures, and disciplinary conventions that students then reproduce in their own writing (Kalule, 2013).

References

Flower, L., & Hayes, J. R. (1981). A cognitive process theory of writing. *College Composition and Communication*, 32(4), 365–387.

Kalule, J. (2013). *Writing right: Enhancing academic writing and research among post graduate students in public universities in Uganda*. Makerere University.

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Question 8(a)

Clarity and audience awareness are two interdependent pillars of effective academic communication. Without them, even substantively strong writing fails to achieve its communicative purpose.

Clear writing is organised writing where the direction, meaning, and overall arguments are evident, and the reader does not have to work to understand what the writer is trying to convey. In academic contexts, clarity is not merely a stylistic preference but an ethical obligation. Writing that obscures meaning through vague language, disorganised structure, or unnecessary complexity withholds understanding from its audience and undermines the scholarly enterprise.

Audience awareness complements clarity by requiring writers to actively consider who will read their work and what those readers bring in terms of knowledge, expectations, and purpose. A text may be characterised as audience aware when it adopts an appropriate rhetorical stance, register, diction, tone, and voice, and employs the conventions and writing style that the target audience expects.

In the scenario, the university academic magazine serves a mixed readership of students, academics, and educated general readers. Neither article meets this audience's needs. The excessively informal article disrespects the academic context of the publication, whilst the highly technical article erects an unnecessary barrier between the writer's ideas and the reader's understanding. Audience awareness is directly mentioned in the majority of higher education writing frameworks as the ability to present arguments with clarity and accuracy in forms suitable for the audiences being addressed. Both failures, therefore, stem from the same root: insufficient consideration of who the writing is for (Kalule, 2013).

References

IUP Centre for Scholarly Communication. (n.d.). *Clear, precise, and concise writing in scholarly communication*. Indiana University of Pennsylvania.

Kalule, J. (2013). *Writing right: Enhancing academic writing and research among post graduate students in public universities in Uganda*. Makerere University.

Writing Commons. (n.d.). *Audience awareness: How to boost clarity in communications*. Writing Commons.

Question 8(b)

Formal and informal communication styles represent two distinct ends of a linguistic register spectrum, each serving different purposes, contexts, and audiences.

Formal communication is characterised by precise vocabulary, evidence-based argumentation, objective tone, and adherence to grammatical conventions. It avoids contractions, colloquialisms, and first-person personal opinion. The purpose of scholarly writing is to share research and discuss findings with a primarily expert audience, making a more formal writing style appropriate as it establishes the proper tone for the work. For example, a formal sentence reads: "The findings suggest a statistically significant relationship between socioeconomic status and academic attainment," whilst its informal equivalent might read: "Poor kids do worse in school."

Informal communication, by contrast, employs everyday language, personal address, contractions, and relaxed sentence structures. Word choice represents the most visible marker of formality; informal writing employs everyday language, colloquialisms, and vague terms familiar from conversation, whilst formal academic writing selects precise vocabulary that conveys exact meaning and demonstrates subject knowledge.

Applied to the scenario, the excessively informal article likely uses language appropriate for a personal blog or social media post, undermining its credibility within an academic magazine. The highly technical article, by contrast, assumes a specialist readership that the magazine's broader audience does not represent. Both failures illustrate that register is not fixed but must be calibrated deliberately to the communicative context (Purdue Global Writing Centre, 2020).

References

Purdue Global Writing Centre. (2020). *Formal vs. informal writing*. Purdue University Global.

University of Southern California Libraries. (n.d.). *Academic writing style*. University of Southern California.

Question 8(c)

Both extremes of register carry serious consequences for academic communication, though they manifest differently depending on which end of the spectrum the writer occupies.

Excessively informal writing erodes the writer's scholarly credibility. In academia, credibility and academic tone function as currency; informality may distract readers or

reduce their trust in the writer's arguments. When a university magazine article employs slang, contractions, or unsupported personal opinions, it signals to the reader that the writer has not engaged seriously with the subject. The argument, however sound, becomes difficult to take seriously when it is dressed in casual, conversational language inappropriate to the scholarly context.

Excessively technical writing carries an equally damaging but opposite danger: exclusion. Overly complex academic writing raises walls around research that bar the public from engaging with important work, and disadvantages students who may have had less exposure to the realities of higher education, potentially deterring them through its seeming inaccessibility. Furthermore, jargon use has been shown to lower comprehension and decrease processing fluency, the metacognitive experience of the ease with which new information is processed.

In the scenario, both articles ultimately fail their readers. The informal article forfeits credibility; the technical article forfeits comprehension. Neither serves the magazine's purpose of communicating ideas accessibly to an educated but non-specialist audience, demonstrating that stylistic extremes are not merely aesthetic failures but communicative ones (Purdue OWL, n.d.).

References

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Purdue Online Writing Lab. (n.d.). *Group jargon*. Purdue University.

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Question 8(d)

Achieving the right balance between professionalism, clarity, and reader engagement requires deliberate, audience-centred strategies rather than defaulting to either extreme of register.

The first strategy is **conducting audience analysis before writing**. Writers should ask who their readers are, what they already know, and what level of formality and technical detail suits the publication's purpose. For the university magazine in the scenario, this analysis would reveal a mixed readership requiring formal but accessible prose.

The second strategy is **defining technical terms on first use**. Balancing the need for precision with the requirement to communicate effectively to a broader audience is a

common challenge; avoiding overuse of jargon or technical terms unless they are essential to the subject matter prevents alienating readers outside the field. When specialist language is unavoidable, brief, plain-language definitions maintain both rigour and accessibility.

The third strategy is **using active voice and varied sentence structures**. Tone and style help balance professionalism with readability, preventing ambiguity and misinterpretation, and academic tone should be objective and formal but readable. Short, direct sentences punctuated by longer analytical ones sustain reader engagement without sacrificing scholarly weight.

The fourth strategy is **seeking editorial peer feedback before submission**. An independent reader from the intended audience can identify passages where the writing is either too casual or too opaque, enabling targeted revision before publication. Makerere University's academic writing guidelines similarly emphasise the value of iterative review and feedback as central to producing writing that is both credible and communicative (Makerere University Directorate of Research and Graduate Training, 2011).

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Question 9(a)

The statement "Because many students have not yet cleared tuition" is grammatically incomplete. It constitutes a **sentence fragment**, specifically a subordinate clause fragment, which cannot stand alone as a meaningful sentence.

Subordinate clause fragments are logically incomplete; they begin with a subordinating conjunction that makes the reader expect more information than the fragment provides, as the subordinator prevents the clause from expressing a complete thought.

The word "Because" is a subordinating conjunction that signals a causal relationship, immediately raising the question: what happened as a result? A dependent clause may

contain a subject and a verb but begins a thought it does not finish; the word "because" is responsible for making the clause dependent.

Whilst the statement contains a subject ("many students") and a verb phrase ("have not yet cleared"), it lacks an independent clause to complete the thought. The reader is left waiting for a consequence or conclusion that never arrives. In formal academic writing, sentence fragments undermine the writer's authority and distract the reader. In institutional communication particularly, this incompleteness creates confusion and projects administrative carelessness.

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Question 9(b)

These four grammatical structures are distinct in what they contain and whether they can function as complete sentences.

A **phrase** is a group of words that lacks both a subject and a predicate and cannot stand alone. A phrase is a group of words acting as a unit that does not include a subject and a predicate, and if used alone it would be a sentence fragment. Example: "many students" or "clearing tuition fees."

A **clause** is a group of words containing both a subject and a verb. There are two types of clauses, dependent and independent, and both contain a subject and a verb but differ in whether they express a complete thought.

An **independent clause** contains a subject, verb, and complete thought, and can stand alone as a sentence. Example: "Students must clear their tuition fees before registration."

A **dependent clause** contains a subject and verb but cannot stand alone because it does not express a complete thought. A dependent clause contains a subject and verb but does not express a complete thought and therefore cannot function as a sentence on its own. Example: "Because many students have not yet cleared tuition" requires an independent clause to complete it, such as: "Because many students have not yet cleared tuition, registration has been suspended."

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Question 9(c)

"Please be advised that registration for the upcoming semester has been suspended because many students have not yet cleared their tuition fees. All affected students are urged to visit the Finance Office and settle their outstanding balances by Friday, 30th May 2026, to avoid further inconvenience."

Question 9(d)

Sentence completeness and clarity are not merely grammatical concerns; they are ethical and operational imperatives in institutional communication. Cutlip and Center (1952, as cited in Communication Theory, 2023) identify completeness as one of the foundational principles of effective communication, arguing that recipients have a right to receive full information in order to follow a sender's reasoning and act appropriately.

In institutional contexts such as universities, incomplete or ambiguous messages create confusion, erode trust, and can produce adverse consequences for students who misinterpret directives. Nuraini and Ramli (2023) establish that well-formed sentences directly shape how readers interpret messages, and that poor sentence construction in professional settings undermines both the credibility of the institution and the practical outcomes it seeks to achieve.

The administrator's fragment "because many students have not yet cleared tuition" exemplifies this risk. Without a main clause, the message leaves the reader uncertain about what action is required, by whom, and by when. In high-stakes institutional contexts, such ambiguity is not a minor stylistic lapse but a failure of communicative responsibility (Widiastuti and Nugroho, 2022).

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Question 10(a)

Understanding the four sentence types is fundamental to effective written communication, as each type serves a distinct grammatical and rhetorical function.

A simple sentence contains one independent clause, that is, one subject and one predicate expressing a complete thought. Example: *The journalist filed the report.*

A compound sentence joins two or more independent clauses using a coordinating conjunction (for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so) or a semicolon. Each clause can stand alone, but they are combined to show a relationship between ideas (CSUCHICO, n.d.). Example: *The editor approved the article, and it was published immediately.*

A complex sentence contains one independent clause and at least one dependent clause, linked by a subordinating conjunction such as "because," "although," or "when." The dependent clause cannot stand alone as a complete sentence (University of Evergreen, 2023). Example: *Although the event was controversial, the journalist reported it objectively.*

A compound-complex sentence combines at least two independent clauses and one or more dependent clauses, making it the most structurally sophisticated sentence type (University of Bristol, n.d.). Example: *Although the press conference ran late, the journalist submitted her report on time, and her editor commended her professionalism.*

Each sentence type offers the writer a different degree of grammatical complexity and expressive range, and skilled writers deploy all four strategically to serve their communicative purpose (Nuraini and Ramli, 2023).

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Question 10(b)

Writers vary sentence structures for three principal reasons: to maintain reader engagement, to emphasise key ideas, and to express logical relationships between thoughts with greater precision.

From a reader engagement standpoint, uniform sentence structure creates monotony. A succession of simple sentences produces a choppy, immature rhythm, whilst an unbroken sequence of long sentences becomes cognitively taxing (CSUCHICO, n.d.). GrammarFlip (2024) confirms that mixing sentence types creates a natural rhythm that holds a reader's attention and makes writing appear more articulate and purposeful.

Beyond rhythm, sentence variation serves a rhetorical function. Proof-Reading-Service (2025) notes that compound sentences connect balanced ideas, complex sentences express causal and contrastive relationships, and compound-complex sentences allow writers to embed layered reasoning within a single, controlled structure. Each type therefore carries a distinct communicative weight that a writer selects deliberately to match their argumentative purpose.

In journalism specifically, this matters greatly. A journalist covering a national event uses short, declarative sentences to deliver urgent facts swiftly, then shifts to longer complex or compound-complex structures to contextualise those facts, analyse implications, and guide the reader through nuance (Journalism University, 2025). This deliberate variation is not stylistic decoration but a disciplined tool for controlling how information is received.

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Question 10(c)

Sentence variety the deliberate alternation between simple, compound, complex, and compound-complex structures is far more than a stylistic flourish. It is a functional and rhetorical strategy that directly shapes how readers comprehend, respond to, and remain engaged with a text. In journalism and academic writing alike, the structural choices a writer makes at the sentence level determine whether an argument lands with precision, carries persuasive force, or sustains a reader's attention to the final word.

Clarity is perhaps the most immediate benefit of varied sentence structure. Different structures are suited to communicating different logical relationships. A simple sentence excels at delivering a hard, unambiguous fact; a complex sentence, by contrast, allows the writer to articulate conditions, causes, and contrasts that simple syntax cannot capture. As Solikhah (2017) demonstrated in her experimental study, sentence variety was found to be the single most dominant technique in improving the overall quality of academic essays, contributing to quality improvement at a rate of 58.5% outperforming both grammatical correction and detail development. This finding underscores that clarity in writing is not merely a matter of correctness; it is fundamentally a structural achievement. When a journalist, for instance, moves between "The suspect was arrested." and "Although witnesses gave conflicting accounts, investigators determined that the suspect had been present at the scene," they are not varying style arbitrarily they are matching sentence architecture to conceptual complexity, thereby reducing the cognitive load on the reader (Solikhah, 2017).

Persuasion is equally shaped by sentence structure. Classical rhetoric, from Aristotle onward, has recognised that style is not mere ornamentation but one of the available means of arousing appropriate emotional response in an audience (Winterowd, as cited in Clary-Lemon et al., 2011). In practice, skilled writers deploy short sentences at decisive rhetorical moments after an elaborate compound-complex sentence that has built a case, a short sentence falls like a verdict. Consider the difference between a journalist who writes "Despite government assurances, repeated delays, funding gaps, and contradictory ministerial statements, the project has failed" versus one who closes with simply: "It has

failed." The blunt conclusion derives its persuasive weight from the contrast in structure. Proof-Reading-Service.com (2025) notes that sentence variety allows writers to "emphasise key results, concepts or arguments" and that strategic variation distinguishes competent prose from truly persuasive scholarly argumentation. Furthermore, the "rule of three" grouping ideas in triads across sentence structures has been consistently observed to increase memorability and rhetorical satisfaction for readers (Writing for Success, 2015).

Reader engagement is sustained through rhythm. Just as spoken monotone loses an audience regardless of content quality, written prose that repeats the same sentence structure becomes fatiguing even when the ideas are sound. Varied sentence length creates a natural reading cadence: longer sentences build momentum and accumulate reasoning, while shorter ones provide emphasis and relief. As GrammarFlip (2024) explains, sentence variety "prevents monotony and keeps readers interested," enabling writers to "convey tone and mood" and "deliver a more nuanced message." In journalism, where a reader may abandon an article within seconds, this rhythm is not incidental it is the mechanism through which the writer earns continued attention. In academic writing, it performs an additional function: demonstrating linguistic competence. Proof-Reading-Service.com (2025) notes that varied structures "signal linguistic competence and academic maturity," subtly reinforcing the writer's credibility and, by extension, the persuasiveness of the argument itself.

In summary, sentence variety is an indispensable tool in both journalism and academic writing. It is the structural means by which clarity of meaning, force of persuasion, and sustained reader engagement are simultaneously achieved. Writers who neglect it risk producing prose that is technically correct but intellectually inert.

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Question 10(d)

Writing (Uganda Context)

The following are original examples illustrating each of the four sentence types simple, compound, complex, and compound-complex drawn from Ugandan journalism and academic writing contexts. Each example is accompanied by an explanation of its structural function and communicative effect.

Simple Sentence (Journalism):

"Makerere University has launched a new e-learning platform."

This simple sentence, comprising a single independent clause, delivers a news fact with immediacy and precision. In Ugandan journalism as practised in outlets such as the *Daily Monitor* and *New Vision* the opening line of a news report (the lead) is typically structured this way. The inverted pyramid format, which prioritises the most critical information first, relies on simple sentences to orient the reader instantly (Vaia, 2024). There is no ambiguity, no subordination, no delay: the reader knows who did what and can decide immediately whether to read on. The simplicity here is not a limitation; it is a deliberate communicative choice that serves clarity above all else.

Compound Sentence (Journalism):

"Internet connectivity in rural districts of Uganda remains unreliable, yet student enrolment in online degree programmes at Makerere University has grown steadily since 2021."

This compound sentence joins two independent clauses using the coordinating conjunction *yet*, which signals contrast. The structure is particularly effective in journalism when a writer needs to present two equally significant but opposing facts without reducing

one to a subordinate position. The contrast between limited infrastructure and growing participation reflects real tensions documented in research on e-learning adoption at Makerere University, where inadequate infrastructure was identified as a key challenge even as uptake expanded (Namatovu & Arinaitwe, 2024). By giving each clause equal grammatical weight, the writer respects both realities and invites the reader to hold the tension between them – a fundamentally journalistic act.

Complex Sentence (Academic Writing):

"Although the Ministry of Education and Sports launched a national digital strategy in August 2024, many students in northern and eastern Uganda continue to lack access to the devices and connectivity required to benefit from online learning initiatives."

This complex sentence uses a subordinating conjunction (*although*) to establish a concessive relationship: acknowledging a positive development whilst immediately qualifying its limitations. In academic writing – for instance, in a Makerere University research paper on educational equity – this structure is essential for nuanced argumentation. It avoids overstating either progress or failure, which is a hallmark of scholarly integrity. As Proof-Reading-Service.com (2025) observes, complex sentences allow writers to "express different logical relationships" such as contrast, condition, and cause, which simple or compound sentences cannot achieve with the same economy of language.

Compound-Complex Sentence (Academic Writing):

"Although phase one of Makerere University's e-learning initiative, supported by the Mastercard Foundation and implemented between 2021 and 2024, produced measurable gains in digital capacity among academic staff, significant disparities in access persist across different student populations, and the university must therefore address both infrastructural and pedagogical gaps before the second phase can achieve equitable outcomes."

This compound-complex sentence brings together two independent clauses (*significant disparities persist* and *the university must address gaps*) with a dependent clause (*although phase one produced gains*), forming a multi-layered argument within a single grammatical unit. In academic writing, this structure is used to synthesise evidence, acknowledge complexity, and drive towards a reasoned conclusion – all simultaneously. The evidence embedded in this example draws on documented outcomes from Makerere

University's e-learning initiative (Makerere University News, 2025). Such sentences, when well-constructed, demonstrate the intellectual sophistication that Solikhah (2017) associates with high-quality academic essays.

These four examples collectively demonstrate that sentence type selection is not arbitrary. In Ugandan journalism, simpler structures serve the public interest by making information immediately accessible; in Ugandan academic writing, more complex structures reflect the depth of analysis that institutional and scholarly audiences demand. Mastery of all four types enables both journalists and academics to communicate with precision, credibility, and impact.

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Question 11(a)

The four sentences used by the lecturer during the online lecture each perform a distinct communicative function, as analysed below:

1. "Submit your assignments before Friday." This is an **imperative sentence**. Its function is to issue a **command or instruction** directed at the students. The subject (*you*) is implied

rather than stated, and the sentence opens directly with a verb (*Submit*), which is the defining structural feature of imperatives. Its purpose is to regulate student behaviour and enforce a deadline (Grammarist, 2022).

2. "Did everyone access the reading materials?" This is an **interrogative sentence**. Its function is to **request information** specifically, to establish whether students have completed a preparatory task. It is structured with an auxiliary verb (*Did*) placed before the subject (*everyone*), which is characteristic of interrogative construction. In a teaching context, it additionally serves to check comprehension and prompt student accountability (Linguistics Girl, 2023).

3. "The discussion forum closes tonight." This is a **declarative sentence**. Its function is to **convey information or state a fact** in this case, notifying students of a deadline. It follows the standard subject-verb structure (*The discussion forum + closes*) and ends with a full stop. Declarative sentences are the most prevalent type in academic and instructional communication because they are the primary vehicle for delivering information (Brinton & Brinton, 2010, as cited in Linguistics Girl, 2023).

4. "What an excellent presentation!" This is an **exclamatory sentence**. Its function is to **express strong positive emotion** here, admiration and encouragement. It begins with *What*, a typical marker of exclamatory construction, and ends with an exclamation mark. In a pedagogical setting, such sentences serve an affective function, motivating students and reinforcing positive participation (Jiang & Ren, 2023).

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Question 11(b)

Sentences in the English language are classified not only by their structure but also by their **communicative function** that is, the purpose they serve in a given interaction. Verspoor and Sauter (2000, as cited in UK Essays, 2023) identify four fundamental sentence types based on communicative function: declarative, interrogative, imperative, and exclamatory. Each carries distinct syntactic properties and serves a specific communicative role.

Declarative Sentences

A declarative sentence makes a statement, conveys a fact, or provides information. It follows the standard subject-verb word order and ends with a full stop. As Shopen (2007, as cited in UK Essays, 2023) notes, the declarative sentence is used chiefly to make an assertion stating a fact, a possibility, or even an opinion. It is the most prevalent sentence type in both spoken and written English, forming the backbone of academic writing, news reporting, and instructional communication. Example: *"The discussion forum closes tonight."* Here, the lecturer is stating a fact with no emotional colouring or directive force.

Interrogative Sentences

An interrogative sentence asks a question and ends with a question mark. Its characteristic syntactic feature is subject-auxiliary inversion the auxiliary verb is placed before the subject or the use of interrogative words such as *who, what, when, where, how, or why* (Grammarist, 2022). Interrogative sentences serve to elicit information, verify understanding, or prompt reflection. Example: *"Did everyone access the reading materials?"* The auxiliary *Did* precedes the subject *everyone*, marking it unmistakably as interrogative. According to Linguistics Girl (2023), interrogative sentences function to "request information or ask questions," making them essential tools for dialogue and critical engagement.

Imperative Sentences

An imperative sentence issues a command, instruction, request, or piece of advice. Its defining syntactic feature is the absence of an explicit subject: the subject *you* is understood but omitted, and the sentence opens directly with a base verb (EnglishClub, n.d.). Imperative sentences may end with either a full stop or an exclamation mark, depending on the degree of urgency intended. Example: *"Submit your assignments before Friday."* The verb *submit* opens the sentence, signalling a directive. In institutional and educational contexts, imperative sentences are indispensable for regulating behaviour and communicating expectations clearly.

Exclamatory Sentences

An exclamatory sentence expresses strong emotion such as surprise, admiration, excitement, or alarm and always ends with an exclamation mark (Grammarist, 2022). A notable structural variant begins with *What* or *How* and functions as an emphatic declaration rather than a question. Linguistics Girl (2023) makes an important scholarly observation: exclamatory sentences are not an entirely independent syntactic category but are declarative, interrogative, or imperative sentences rendered exclamatory through added emphasis and punctuation. Example: "*What an excellent presentation!*" This begins with *What*, carries strong admiration, and ends with an exclamation mark all hallmarks of an exclamatory sentence in form and function.

It is worth noting, as EnglishClub (n.d.) cautions, that form and function do not always coincide. A declarative sentence such as "*You will submit your work now*" can function as a command, and an interrogative such as "*Could you please log in?*" may function as a polite request rather than a genuine question. Context, intonation, and punctuation therefore remain essential to accurate interpretation.

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Question 11(c)

Teaching and Learning Environments

The four sentence types declarative, interrogative, imperative, and exclamatory are not neutral grammatical categories. In teaching and learning environments, each performs a distinct social and pedagogical function that directly shapes the **tone** of the classroom and the **degree to which students feel invited, directed, or motivated to participate**.

This is particularly significant in online lecture settings, where physical cues are absent and language carries the full weight of communicative interaction.

Declarative sentences and informational tone

Declarative sentences establish the informational foundation of any lesson. When a lecturer states, "*The discussion forum closes tonight*," the tone is neutral and authoritative; it communicates facts without inviting debate or dialogue. In teaching, this sentence type creates clarity and predictability, setting out the parameters within which students operate. However, an over-reliance on declarative sentences can produce a one-directional, lecturer-centred environment where students remain passive recipients of information rather than active participants. Research on teacher-student interaction in online learning confirms that the quality and variety of teacher discourse directly affects students' learning engagement and psychological comfort in the learning space (Zhang, as cited in National Center for Biotechnology Information [NCBI], 2022). A lecture dominated by declarative sentences alone, whilst clear, risks reducing student agency.

Interrogative sentences and participatory tone

Interrogative sentences are among the most powerful tools a lecturer possesses for promoting active student participation. When a lecturer asks, "*Did everyone access the reading materials?*" the tone shifts from informational to dialogic; students are directly addressed and implicitly called upon to respond. This invites accountability and opens a communicative channel. As research on teacher-student interaction in online environments demonstrates, effective interaction positively affects learning outcomes, with the level of teacher-student interaction correlating significantly with students' learning effects ($r = 0.649, p < 0.01$) (NCBI, 2022). Interrogative sentences are the primary syntactic mechanism through which this interaction is initiated. They signal to students that their knowledge, opinions, and experiences are valued—a condition essential for fostering genuine intellectual engagement in higher education settings such as those at Makerere University.

Imperative sentences and directive tone

Imperative sentences set the tone of authority and structure. "*Submit your assignments before Friday*" is direct, unambiguous, and action-orientated. In teaching contexts, imperatives are indispensable for managing classroom behaviour, communicating deadlines, and issuing instructions clearly. However, the tone they create is inherently asymmetric: the lecturer as authority figure directs; the student as recipient complies. Whilst necessary, an overuse of imperatives can create an environment that feels controlling or intimidating, potentially discouraging students from asking questions or

contributing voluntarily. TeachThought (2025) notes that the language a teacher uses, including its tone and underlying implications, significantly shapes whether students feel "supported, empowered, safe, and absolutely integral to their own success." Imperatives must therefore be balanced with more inclusive sentence types to avoid creating a climate of passive compliance.

Exclamatory sentences and motivational tone

Exclamatory sentences carry the greatest affective charge of all four types. When a lecturer says, "*What an excellent presentation!*" the tone becomes warm, celebratory, and affirming. In a pedagogical context, this sentence type performs a crucial motivational function: it acknowledges student effort publicly, reinforces positive behaviour, and cultivates a classroom climate of encouragement. This is particularly vital in online learning environments, where students are physically separated from the lecturer and may feel disconnected or undervalued. The psychological atmosphere created by positive lecturer language has been shown to mediate the relationship between teacher-student interaction and learning outcomes (NCBI, 2022). Exclamatory affirmation, used judiciously, contributes directly to that atmosphere.

In summary, sentence function is a pedagogical instrument. A thoughtful lecturer deploys all four sentence types strategically: informing through declaratives, engaging through interrogatives, directing through imperatives, and motivating through exclamatives to create a teaching and learning environment that is simultaneously structured, participatory, and affirming.

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Question 12 (a)

The public health message posted by the government ministry reads: "*People who are sick avoid public places wear masks wash hands regularly.*" This sentence is entirely devoid of punctuation, and the consequences for its meaning are severe. Far from being a minor stylistic oversight, the absence of punctuation in this message renders it structurally ambiguous, potentially dangerous, and communicatively ineffective. Understanding why requires a close examination of how punctuation functions as a meaning-making system in written language.

Punctuation is a fundamental component of written communication that structures sentences, signals grammatical relationships, and guides the reader's interpretation of a text. Tandfonline (2023) defines punctuation as an essential aspect of written language that "helps to clarify structure and meaning, and can reduce ambiguity." Unlike spoken communication, where tone, pause, stress, and intonation naturally separate ideas and signal intent, written language depends entirely on punctuation to perform these functions (Kitces, 2024). When punctuation is removed, the reader is left to mentally reconstruct the intended meaning without any reliable textual cues, a process that is neither foolproof nor consistent across different readers (ResearchGate, 2025).

In the ministry's message, the absence of punctuation creates a critical ambiguity: it is impossible to determine with certainty whether the sentence is directed at sick people alone, or at all members of the public. A correctly punctuated version such as, "People who are sick should avoid public places. Everyone should wear masks and wash hands regularly," communicates two distinct and clearly separated instructions. Without punctuation, the message collapses into a single continuous stream of text that a reader may interpret as applying exclusively to sick individuals, potentially leading healthy members of the public to believe that mask-wearing and handwashing are not required of them. In a disease outbreak context, this misinterpretation could have life-threatening consequences.

Preply (2026) illustrates this principle with a well-known example: "Let's eat, grandma!" versus "Let's eat grandma!" The comma changes the meaning entirely, distinguishing an invitation from what appears to be a threat. Similarly, in the ministry's message, the

presence or absence of a full stop, comma, or other punctuation mark fundamentally alters who is being addressed and what action is required of them. As the KPU Communication at Work textbook notes, errors in grammar and punctuation "lead to readers' and audiences' confusion and frustration, which get in the way of their understanding the meaning you intended" (KPU Press, n.d.).

Beyond ambiguity, the absence of punctuation also undermines the credibility and authority of the communicating institution. In official public communication, particularly during emergencies, readers expect precision, clarity, and a demonstration of institutional competence. Research on digital miscommunication confirms that omission, misuse, and overuse of punctuation "directly affect message perception," reducing the reader's trust in the communicator (ResearchGate, 2025). A government ministry that issues an unpunctuated public health advisory during a disease outbreak risks not only misunderstanding but also a loss of public confidence at precisely the moment when trust is most needed.

In sum, punctuation is not a decorative addition to written text; it is an indispensable structural tool that assigns meaning, directs attention, clarifies intent, and governs interpretation. Its omission in the ministry's message transforms what should be a clear, actionable public health directive into an ambiguous, potentially harmful piece of writing.

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Question 12(b)

Sentence structure, or syntax, serves as the cognitive blueprint that guides an audience's decoding process. In the provided message, the absence of a clear syntactic hierarchy creates a 'run-on' effect, leading to structural ambiguity. According to Crystal (2017), the arrangement of constituents such as subjects, verbs, and objects determines the "thematic prominence" of a message.

In this instance, the lack of conjunctions or subordinate clauses fails to distinguish whether the phrase is a **declarative statement** describing the behaviour of sick people or a series of **imperative commands**. Without a clear structure, the audience may experience a "garden-path" effect, where they must re-read the sentence multiple times to mentally insert the necessary breaks required to extract the intended directive (Harley, 2014). Consequently, poor structure does not merely obscure the message; it shifts the cognitive burden to the reader, often leading to misinterpretation or total disregard of the instruction.

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Question 12(c)

Unclear communication during emergencies precipitates a breakdown in the 'social contract' between health authorities and the public. Ambiguity fosters cognitive dissonance; when an audience is unable to decipher official directives such as the provided run-on sentence they often revert to heuristic-based decision-making or follow unverified community rumours (Musoke, 2018).

Within the Ugandan public health landscape, research indicates that during viral outbreaks, vague messaging significantly reduces adherence to preventative measures. As Tusingwire et al. (2021) argue, if the structural integrity of a message is compromised, the urgency of the threat is often downplayed by the recipient. This 'semantic noise' acts as a

barrier to collective action, erodes institutional trust, and ultimately increases morbidity rates through delayed or incorrect public response.

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Question 12(d)

To maintain professionalism and ensure public safety, government entities must adopt a **strategic communication framework** that prioritises readability and precision. Firstly, the implementation of the **Plain English Movement** principles is essential; this involves using short, declarative sentences and avoiding the "stacking" of verbs without proper punctuation (Cutts, 2020). For the message in question, a punctuated, bulleted list or the use of semi-colons would transform the ambiguity into actionable directives.

Secondly, official messages should undergo **pre-distribution testing** or "linguistic auditing" within target communities to identify potential misinterpretations before digital publication. According to Makerere University's communication guidelines, professional correspondence must also maintain a formal tone that reflects institutional authority, utilizing standard grammar to preserve credibility (Ssentongo, 2019). By employing these strategies, ministries can ensure that emergency instructions are cognitively accessible, thereby fostering immediate compliance.

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